Insights into Immigration Trends in Chile: Challenges in integrating migrants into the Labour Market

Guidance note - Promotional measures

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1. Main recent migratory flows in Chile.

1.1. The migratory situation in Chile over the last 10 years.

- Before the 2000s Chile was not among the most important migratory destinations within Latin America (Gissi and Andrade, 2022).
- There have been two important migratory flows in Chile since 1990, the first one in 1996 and the second one since 2016.
- The migratory flow from 1996, was mainly composed by Peruvian population, country that shares a border with Chile.
- The second one, which started in 2016, brought migrants coming from Venezuela, Haiti and Colombia, countries that do not share a border with Chile (Gissi, Ghio and Silva, 2019; INE and DEM, 2020, as cited in Gissi and Andrade, 2022)

1.2. Growth and change in the composition of the migrant population.

- In 2015, immigrants represented 3% of the Chilean population while in 2022 they reached 8,8% (with a total of 1.7 million foreigners) (Ministerio de Desarrollo Social y Familia de Chile, 2024).
- Before 2016, Haitians and Venezuelans were not even part of the top ten countries of origin of immigrants in Chile (OIM Chile, 2019).
- In 2017, the Venezuelan population took the first place in the proportion of immigrants in Chile, leaving Peruvian immigrants in second place. In 2022 Venezuelans represented 49,2% of immigrants in Chile, while Peruvians with the second place represented only 13,5% (Ministerio de Desarrollo Social y Familia de Chile, 2024).
- The reason for both, Haitians and Venezuelans to go to Chile is a mix of poor economic performance and political and social instability (Navarrete, 2015; OIM Chile, 2019)

1.3. In general, immigrants have a better performance in the labour market and also have access to the social protection system.

- The 2022 National Migration Survey covers the immigrant population over 18 years of age who arrived in Chile between 2016 and 2020 and who intend to stay (process initiated). Venezuelans represent 45% and Haitians 19% of the total. The rest of the countries are Colombia, Peru and Bolivia.
- The recent migrant population is young. More than 70% of them are between 18 and 39 years old.

- They present high labor participation rate (95% and 84% for men and women respectively) and employment rate (92% and 77% for men and women respectively). Immigrants have higher rates than Chileans.
- Most of employed immigrants work as wage earners (79%), who mostly pay contributions to the health system (whether public or private).
- 80% of the immigrants are part of the social registry of households, the national targeting instrument (World Bank, 2022).

2. Identification of the main challenges to integrating migrants into the Labour Market.

2.1. Increasing level of informality.

- Although the level of informality among Chileans and foreigners was similar, after the pandemic, the situation has worsened for immigrants (World Bank, 2023).
- Informality can largely be explained by a significant increase in the irregular migrant population.
- It is estimated that in 2023 around 18% of immigrants were in an irregular situation, 75% of which are Venezuelans (Servicio Nacional de Migraciones de Chile, 2023).

2.2. Venezuelans are highly educated, but more than half do not practice their profession.

- Venezuelans are particularly highly educated, with almost 65% of them having reached the tertiary education. This value ranges between 39% and 10% for the rest of the countries of origin.
- Almost half of them belong to Engineering and Technology careers (47,4%).
- Nevertheless, only 1 out of 10 Venezuelan professionals have validated their higher education studies in the Chilean system (World Bank, 2022).[1]
- Only 46% of employed Venezuelans that finished tertiary education perform work related to their profession.
- The complexity of the requirements, the cost and the length of the process discourage immigrants. 54% of the cases took more than 6 months, and 26% took 1 year or more (World Bank, 2023).

2.3. Haitians face a language barrier.

- Among the countries with the largest presence in Chile, Haiti is the only non-Spanish speaking country.
- 61% of Haitians define their Spanish speaking level as regular, bad or very bad (World Bank, 2022). This represents a significant barrier to their integration (World Bank, 2023).

3. Possible solutions and current efforts, if any.

3.1. About the informality and irregular status.

- Since the informality is highly related to irregular immigration status. The first step would be to ease the access to information about the process and the necessary requirements and documents, in addition to speeding up the processes (World Bank, 2023).

[1] Colombians have a higher proportion of professionals that have done this validation. This is due to agreements between the Chilean and Colombian governments for the process of validating titles.

- Considering that the major part of the migrant population with regular status are part of the social protection system, this could be an important starting point.

3.2. Validation of higher education studies for Venezuelans.

- Venezuela is not among the list of countries that have an agreement with the Chilean government (Ministerio de Educación de Chile). Extending this agreement could speed up the process of recognizing Venezuelans' qualifications. The experience of Colombian immigrants who do have an agreement attests to the good results this can have.
- Including Venezuela in this agreement would be a gain for Chile considering that they represent human capital that the economy would receive without paying for the education (World Bank, 2023).
- There are some institutions that are also involved in the recognition of technical training or working experience like the "Marco Nacional de Cualificaciones" [National Qualifications Framework] and "Chile Valora" [Chile Values] respectively.
- Other institutions involved could be the Ministry of Education, Ministry of Labour and also some other private institutions like the Chilean Confederation of Production and Commerce (CPC).
- Those benefitiaries that can afford should pay, and those that are not able to do it, could have a grace period and once they find employment in their profession they could begin to pay gradually for the recognition of their degrees and/or experience.

3.3. Spanish classes for the social and labor inclusion of Haitians.

- Currently, the state of Chile does not offer Spanish classes for Haitians. Providing this could facilitate better working and living conditions.
- A possible example are the Volkshochschule (VHS) in Germany, which provide low-cost german classes thanks to state subsidies.[2]

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[2]For more information, visit: https://www.volkshochschule.de/